NCCP 00555 · VERSION 7

Your treatment, explained

Metastatic colorectal cancer · NCCP 00555 v7 · Document revised 4 November 2026

Your personal plan: this is the standard regimen schedule. Your team confirms your prescribed doses, cycles, treatment changes and appointments in your written plan.

FOLFOXIRI

14-day cycle

Source reconciled; independent clinical, pharmacy and patient/PPI review pending

ACT ON SYMPTOMS, NOT THE CALENDAR

When to get help

Emergency: call 112 / 999

Severe breathing difficulty, collapse, seizure or severe chest pain: call emergency services. Do not wait for an online answer.

Contact your oncology service immediately

Temperature 37.5°C or higher, 36°C or lower, shivering or suddenly feeling unwell — even with a normal temperature. Fever, shivers or sudden illness needs immediate oncology advice. Chest pain, collapse or severe breathing difficulty needs emergency help. Call urgently for severe or persistent diarrhoea, severe abdominal pain, inability to drink, reduced urine or a line/pump problem.

Follow the urgent contact instructions from your treating hospital. If you cannot reach the team, seek urgent medical assessment. Outside clinic hours, use your instructed out-of-hours pathway or the emergency department.

This page does not diagnose symptoms or decide whether it is safe to stay at home. You do not need to know which medicine caused a symptom before calling.

Open your CUH contact / treatment card

Sources: nccp · hse

Choose a topic to read

YOUR COMPLETE REFERENCE

Read what you need, when you need it.

Start with the overview, explore the cycle, or go straight to a question. Urgent advice is always available.

- How each drug works
- Your treatment plan
- Your 14-day timeline
- Baseline and cycle-specific checks
- Whole treatment, scans and checks
- Your port and treatment pump
- Tablets, visits and practical planning
- Your treatment aim and evidence
- Your treatment schedule
- Before, during and after treatment
- Bowel symptoms and hydration
- Cold sensitivity and longer-lasting nerve symptoms
- Mouth, skin, energy and infection
- Your line and home pump
- Supportive medicines and daily life
- Your paper plan, wallet card and contacts
- Supportive medicines

Understanding the evidence
Questions to ask
Sources

UNDERSTAND YOUR TREATMENT

Your medicines and what they do

FOLFOXIRI combines three chemotherapy medicines with folinic acid to treat colorectal cancer that has spread. The aim is cancer control, symptom relief and, for selected people, a response that allows further local treatment after specialist review.

TOPOISOMERASE I CHEMOTHERAPY

Irinotecan

Campto



Interrupts DNA copying

The body converts irinotecan into SN-38. This traps an enzyme called topoisomerase I while DNA is being copied, causing damage that can stop cancer cells dividing. Normal bowel and blood-forming cells can also be affected.

Irinotecan becomes SN-38 → DNA-repair enzyme is trapped → Dividing cells are damaged

What to watch for

Tell the nurse immediately about cramps, sweating or diarrhoea during the infusion. Diarrhoea starting later needs the separate written treatment and contact plan.

Sources: nccp

PLATINUM CHEMOTHERAPY

Oxaliplatin

Eloxatin



Links DNA strands

Oxaliplatin makes links within DNA. These interfere with copying and repair, which can stop a cancer cell dividing. Healthy tissues can also be affected.

Platinum enters cell → DNA links form → Copying is disrupted

What to watch for

Cold can trigger tingling or throat discomfort. Tell the team about persistent numbness, difficulty with buttons or walking, or infusion symptoms. New breathing difficulty always needs assessment.

Sources: nccp

CHEMOTHERAPY MODULATOR

Folinic acid

Calcium leucovorin



Strengthens fluorouracil action

Folinic acid helps fluorouracil remain bound to an enzyme needed to make DNA. In this regimen it increases fluorouracil activity and can also increase its unwanted effects. It is not a vitamin supplement to start yourself.

Folinic acid → Stronger enzyme binding → Fluorouracil effect increases

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What to watch for

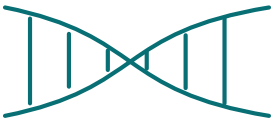
The combined treatment can increase mouth soreness and diarrhoea. Report these promptly. Rare allergic reactions can occur.

Sources: nccp

CHEMOTHERAPY

Fluorouracil

5-FU



Disrupts cell building blocks

Fluorouracil interferes with the production and use of DNA and RNA, the instructions cells need to grow. The infusion extends exposure over approximately two days.

Drug enters cell → DNA / RNA disrupted → Growth slows

What to watch for

Diarrhoea, mouth sores and skin soreness may become serious. Chest pain during the pump infusion needs emergency assessment. Unexpected severe early toxicity can occur even after DPD testing.

Sources: nccp

The drawings are simplified explanations of drug action, not anatomical pictures or a prediction of response.

Explore your existing anatomy and side-effect map

REGIMEN-SPECIFIC SIDE EFFECTS

Your anatomical side-effect map

A picture of side effects

Match each symptom box to its numbered body location. Tell your team about new symptoms.

1 Mouth / swallowing

Fluorouracil + folinic acid

Report ulcers or pain that affects eating or drinking.

3 Bowel / stoma

Irinotecan / fluorouracil

Call early for diarrhoea, increased stoma output or poor intake; severe pain needs urgent assessment.

5 Blood / infection

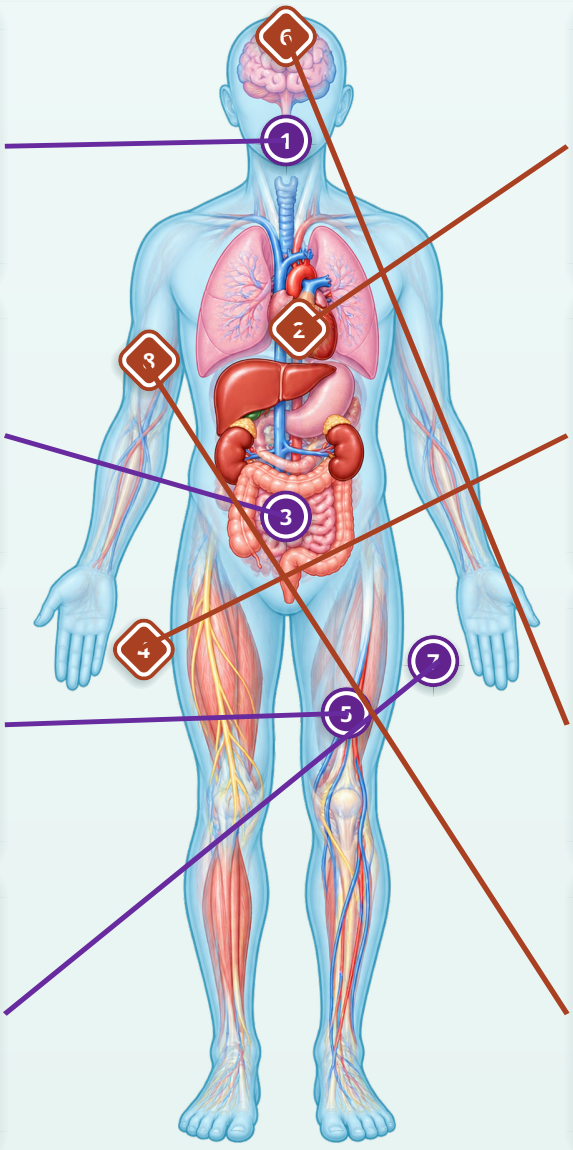
Chemotherapy

Fever, shivers or sudden illness: call now. Unusual bruising or marked weakness also needs advice.

7 Hands / feet

Fluorouracil

Report painful redness, peeling or changes that affect usual activity.



2 Chest

Fluorouracil

New chest pain, collapse or major breathing difficulty needs emergency help.

4 Nerves / cold

Oxaliplatin

Avoid cold triggers; report persistent numbness or difficulty with buttons or walking.

6 Hair / scalp

Irinotecan

Hair thinning or loss may occur. Ask about practical support.

8 Pump / line

Treatment delivery

Call for leakage, swelling, line pain or a loose connection. Do not reconnect it yourself.

Selected effects, not every possible effect or a prediction. Blood-count, skin and line markers are schematic. Number and text carry meaning; colour is decorative.

THE BIGGER TREATMENT PLAN

Your treatment plan

DAY WARD → HOME PUMP → REVIEW

14-day treatment cycle

D1 D2 D3 D14

Day 1: irinotecan, oxaliplatin and folinic acid, followed by a 48-hour fluorouracil pump. Repeat every 14 days while treatment is helping and side effects remain acceptable.

There is no fixed number of cycles for every patient. The team reviews benefit, side effects and your priorities; a break, maintenance approach or drug change needs an individual decision.

Sources: nccp

BASELINE → TREATMENT → FOLLOW-UP

Required and conditional checks across your treatment

Required checks are shown explicitly. ECG, additional urine tests and anticoagulant tests apply only when indicated. Scans and tumour markers follow your individual cancer plan; this page does not prescribe a universal surveillance interval. Confirm who books and reviews each test.

Check	Before starting	During treatment	Between visits	Review / change	After treatment
Blood counts / kidneys / liver	Required baseline blood count, kidney and liver tests	Required before each cycle; results reviewed before treatment	Earlier tests if unwell, dehydrated or toxicity develops	Recovery and results guide delay or dose adjustment	Follow unresolved abnormalities as agreed
DPD / fluoropyrimidine safety	DPD test before fluorouracil or capecitabine unless already tested	The result guides the starting plan; it does not exclude all severe toxicity	Unexpected severe early mouth sores, diarrhoea or illness needs urgent assessment	The team reviews suspected severe reactions before further treatment	Keep the result and any toxicity history in your records
Nerves / cold sensitivity	Record any pre-existing numbness or difficulty with daily tasks	Neuropathy assessment every cycle for this regimen	Report persistent tingling, trouble with buttons or walking; avoid cold triggers	Oxaliplatin may be changed separately after clinical review	Nerve symptoms can persist; arrange follow-up if unresolved
Heart assessment	Review cardiac history; baseline ECG if cardiac function is compromised	Report any new chest pain or breathing change	Chest pain, collapse or severe breathing difficulty needs emergency assessment	Additional heart tests only when clinically indicated	Follow any identified heart problem; no fixed routine echo series

Check	Before starting	During treatment	Between visits	Review / change	After treatment
Response / scans / tumour markers	Agree a baseline disease assessment and treatment aim	Review symptoms, function and clinical benefit	New symptoms may require earlier review	Scans and tumour markers follow the consultant-directed cancer plan	Agree next treatment or follow-up; there is no universal scan interval in this regimen

The team arranges and reviews tests. This guide shows expected timing; it does not record completed appointments. NCCP 00555 v7 · official regimen

THE WHOLE TREATMENT JOURNEY

FOLFOXIRI: treatment and checks

Metastatic colorectal cancer

Day 1: irinotecan, oxaliplatin and folinic acid, followed by a 48-hour fluorouracil pump. Repeat every 14 days while treatment is helping and side effects remain acceptable.

Read from left to right. Columns show stages, not equal lengths of time. This is a general plan: no dates or personal information are needed. Your team confirms which steps apply and arranges appointments.

On a small screen, swipe the map sideways. The checks below give the same timing in words.

Treatment, tests and reviews across the course

Care / check	Before starting	During treatment	Between visits	Review / change	After treatment
Blood counts / kidneys / liver NCCP 00555	Required baseline blood count, kidney and liver tests	Required before each cycle; results reviewed before treatment	Earlier tests if unwell, dehydrated or toxicity develops	Recovery and results guide delay or dose adjustment	Follow unresolved abnormalities as agreed
DPD / fluoropyrimidine safety NCCP 00555	DPD test before fluorouracil or capecitabine unless already tested	The result guides the starting plan; it does not exclude all severe toxicity	Unexpected severe early mouth sores, diarrhoea or illness needs urgent assessment	The team reviews suspected severe reactions before further treatment	Keep the result and any toxicity history in your records
Nerves / cold sensitivity NCCP 00555	Record any pre-existing numbness or difficulty with daily tasks	Neuropathy assessment every cycle for this regimen	Report persistent tingling, trouble with buttons or walking; avoid cold triggers	Oxaliplatin may be changed separately after clinical review	Nerve symptoms can persist; arrange follow-up if unresolved
Heart assessment NCCP 00555	Review cardiac history; baseline ECG if cardiac function is compromised	Report any new chest pain or breathing change	Chest pain, collapse or severe breathing difficulty needs emergency assessment	Additional heart tests only when clinically indicated	Follow any identified heart problem; no fixed routine echo series
Response / scans / tumour markers NCCP 00555	Agree a baseline disease assessment and treatment aim	Review symptoms, function and clinical benefit	New symptoms may require earlier review	Scans and tumour markers follow the consultant-directed cancer plan	Agree next treatment or follow-up; there is no universal scan interval in this regimen

What each check is for

1

14-day treatment cycle

Day ward → home pump → review

FOLFOXIRI combines three chemotherapy medicines with folinic acid to treat colorectal cancer that has spread. The aim is cancer control, symptom relief and, for selected people, a response that allows further local treatment after specialist review.

Ask / act: Confirm the phase, prescription, tests and supportive medicines before starting.

Sources: NCCP 00555

At the next review, ask

- Which treatment phase am I in, and what happens next?
- Which test is expected next, who arranges it, and who explains the result?
- Who should I contact if an expected appointment has not arrived?

This map does not show whether a test has been ordered, booked or completed. Do not wait for a scheduled test if you develop new symptoms.

Sources checked 2026-11-04 · Source reconciled; independent clinical, pharmacy and patient/PPI review pending · SACTCheck v0.84.33

Day 1 → Day 14: a general pattern

This is a visual orientation, not a prediction of your personal cycle. It shows when some effects often emerge and which effects are **not** tied to a particular day.

Day 1: irinotecan, oxaliplatin and folinic acid, followed by a 48-hour fluorouracil pump. Repeat every 14 days while treatment is helping and side effects remain acceptable.

Day of cycle	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14
Day-ward medicines	IV													
Fluorouracil pump	48 hours; disconnect as arranged													
Early cramps / sweating Tell the nurse immediately	Day 1													
Delayed diarrhoea		May start after 24 hours; follow written plan												
Cold sensitivity / nerves	Can occur early and accumulate; report persistent symptoms													

Day of cycle	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14
Blood counts / infection	No guaranteed safe days													
Mouth / bowel / energy	Timing varies; record and report symptoms													

Day ward and home pump: Day 1 infusions lead into a 48-hour pump. The disconnection visit is arranged from the actual connection time.

No safe window: Fever, sudden illness or a serious symptom needs action on any day, including after pump removal.

Treatment review: There is no fixed number of cycles for every patient. The team reviews benefit, side effects and your priorities; a break, maintenance approach or drug change needs an individual decision.

Two different bowel reactions: Cramps and sweating during infusion need immediate nursing attention. Diarrhoea starting more than 24 hours later needs the separate written home plan and early contact.

Between visits: Record symptoms and their effects on drinking, eating, bowel/stoma output, mobility and usual activities.

Why these bands stay broad: Bars show planned treatment and possible symptom patterns, not measured risk. Side effects can overlap and persist. Band length does not show likelihood or severity, and the chart cannot tell you whether it is safe to receive treatment. NCCP 00555 v7 · official regimen ↗️

There are no guaranteed “safe days”. Act on fever, sudden illness or a new serious symptom whenever it occurs. Do not wait for the next appointment.

Read the whole cycle as text

Day 1: Infusion and pump connection

The team checks symptoms, blood results and the active treatment plan. Day-ward infusions are followed by connection of the fluorouracil pump. Before leaving, confirm the pump-care instructions, disconnection appointment and contact number.

Day 2–3: The pump is delivering treatment

The pump runs for approximately 48 hours from connection. Keep the device and line secure and dry as taught. The team confirms the actual disconnection appointment. Call for a leaking, disconnected or unexpectedly stopped pump. Do not reconnect, alter settings or disconnect it yourself unless specifically trained and instructed.

Day 4–7: After disconnection

Delayed diarrhoea can begin after the first 24 hours and may continue after pump removal. Use your written plan and contact the team early. Cold-triggered tingling may occur and nerve symptoms can persist. Nausea and tiredness can overlap; symptoms are not restricted to these days. Report poor intake, persistent diarrhoea or mouth pain early. Chest pain or major breathing difficulty requires emergency help.

Day 8–14: Between visits and the next review

Blood counts can fall between visits. Tell the team about bowel symptoms, mouth pain and how you are managing daily activities. Treatment proceeds only after review. Bring the symptom passport and check the next appointment. Day 1 usually repeats 14 days after this cycle started, only if confirmed.

YOUR TREATMENT, STEP BY STEP

Your port and treatment pump

From preparing the line to coming home after disconnection. Your team arranges the appointments and shows you what to do.



1 · Before treatment

Choose and prepare the line

The team explains whether a port or PICC suits your treatment. You receive instructions for the insertion appointment.



2 · Insertion and recovery

A separate appointment may be needed

For a port, numbing medicine is used and a small device is placed under the skin. Ask about sedation, transport and wound care.



3 · Day 1

The nurse connects your pump

After the day-ward medicines, the nurse checks and connects the fluorouracil pump. Ask for a demonstration before leaving.

4 · At home

Treatment continues for 48 hours

The fluorouracil infusion runs for 48 hours. Carry the pump as shown; protect the dressing and line from pulling, heat and damage.

5 · As arranged

Return for disconnection

A trained professional checks the infusion, disconnects the pump and cares for the line. The appointment is based on connection time.

6 · Between cycles

The access device usually stays

A port needle can be removed while the port stays under the skin. A PICC remains in the arm with ongoing dressing and line care.

Port or PICC: what is the difference?

A port is a small chamber beneath the skin, usually on the chest, attached to a tube ending in a large vein. A special needle goes through the skin into the port when it is used. A PICC enters a vein in the upper arm; a short section remains outside under a dressing. Both can deliver a home infusion. Your team helps choose the device and teaches its care.

Before insertion and during recovery

Tell the team about allergies, blood thinners, infections and any other cancer medicines. Follow the instructions about eating, drinking and transport; do not stop medicines yourself. Port placement uses local anaesthetic, sometimes with sedation or general anaesthetic. The team explains the procedure and risks, including infection, bleeding, clots and insertion complications. Ask how to manage discomfort, protect the wound and resume activity. Report increasing pain, redness, swelling, discharge or fever.

Connection: what the nurse does

The nurse checks the line and treatment, secures the connection and dressing, and starts the pump. Before leaving, you should have the disconnection location and time, contact numbers including out of hours, and the written spill instructions. Ask to be shown what normal pump progress looks like. You do not need to calculate a rate.

Carrying it, sleeping and washing

Use the supplied carrier and the position recommended for your pump. Keep tubing free from pulling and kinks. Ask how to place the pump safely for sleep and how to protect the line and dressing when washing. Do not immerse it or swim. Avoid direct heat and cold. An elastomeric pump has a balloon that shrinks slowly and may have no alarm; an electronic pump has different instructions. Follow the instructions for the device you actually receive.

Disconnection is not port removal

Keep the appointment even if the pump looks empty, unless the team changes the plan. Staff check the pump and line and arrange safe disposal. After flushing and other line care as required, the port needle may be removed and a small dressing applied. The implanted port stays in place until a separate removal procedure is arranged. A PICC remains in place and needs scheduled dressing and flushing care.

Leakage, disconnection or unexpected pump progress

Call the team immediately if the pump leaks, is damaged, finishes unexpectedly early, appears not to run, or the line disconnects. Follow the emergency or spill steps you have been specifically taught, including use of a clamp if instructed. Do not reconnect, change settings or disconnect the pump yourself. Keep other people away from leaked medicine. If medicine touches skin, rinse it off and wash with soap and water, then seek advice.

Pain, swelling or feeling unwell

Contact oncology immediately for pain or swelling around the line, a wet/loose dressing, redness, fever, shivering or suddenly feeling unwell. A painful swollen arm or neck needs urgent advice. Severe chest pain, major breathing difficulty or collapse: call 112 / 999. Do not wait for pump disconnection or the next clinic visit.

The drawings show general steps, not instructions for inserting or accessing a line. Your hospital confirms its own arrangements and the care instructions for your device.

Open the complete port and pump guide · **Printable port and pump guide**

Sources: eviQ: port · eviQ: PICC · eviQ: pump. Reviewed against these sources 16 October 2026; local nursing and patient review pending.

PRACTICAL TREATMENT GUIDE

Practical treatment planning

Agree the arrangements with your oncology team.



STEP 1

Before starting

Confirm the aim, DPD result, test appointments, prescribed supportive medicines and working urgent contact numbers. Bring your full medicines list, including supplements.



STEP 2

Line, pump and disconnection

Agree the access device and care training. The pump runs for 48 hours; confirm the disconnection appointment from its connection time. Do not alter settings, disconnect or reconnect it unless specifically trained and instructed.



STEP 3

If the plan changes

The team confirms the next treatment, blood-test and supportive-medicine dates after a delay or dose change. Do not use a previous calendar as a prescription.



STEP 4

Contacts, paper copies and QR

The example telephone numbers on the wallet card are placeholders. Your team must replace them with working daytime and out-of-hours numbers before patient use. Keep the card with you; the QR opens the regimen information, not your confidential medical record.

Open practical treatment guide · Printable practical guide

Sources: NCCP 00555 v7 · official regimen. Source reconciled; independent clinical, pharmacy and patient/PPI review pending.

MAKE THE PLAN PRACTICAL

Support around the medicines

1 Nausea prevention and rescue

This chemotherapy combination has a high risk of sickness without prevention. Follow the prescribed prevention and rescue medicines. Call if vomiting prevents drinking; do not duplicate steroids or anti-sickness doses.

2 Blood counts and recovery

Growth-factor injections depend on your risk, blood counts and previous complications. If prescribed, confirm their timing in relation to chemotherapy and pump removal; do not assume everyone receives them.

3 Early and delayed diarrhoea plans

Atropine is normally prescribed before irinotecan for early cramps, sweating or diarrhoea. It is avoided with glaucoma; tell the team about asthma as well. At home use the separately prescribed delayed-diarrhoea instructions. This can differ from standard over-the-counter dosing. Keep the medicine and urgent-contact plan available.

4 Cold and mouth care

Avoid cold drinks, cold air and cold objects if they trigger symptoms. Do not use ice chips during oxaliplatin treatment. Ask for non-cold mouth-care advice. New breathing difficulty must still be assessed rather than assumed to be a cold reaction.

Sources: nccp

TREATMENT REFERENCE · 01

Your treatment aim and evidence

The setting and sequence matter.

Why this treatment?

FOLFOXIRI combines three chemotherapy medicines with folinic acid to treat colorectal cancer that has spread. The aim is cancer control, symptom relief and, for selected people, a response that allows further local treatment after specialist review.

Sources: nccp

What studies can tell us

In a randomised study of people starting treatment for metastatic colorectal cancer, FOLFOXIRI improved tumour response and time before progression compared with FOLFIRI, and the study found a survival benefit. The more intensive combination also caused more severe side effects, including low white-cell counts, diarrhoea and nerve symptoms. These group results do not predict an individual outcome.

Sources: trial

Review and your priorities

Ask when benefit will be reviewed and which symptoms, scans or tests will be used. Discuss work, caring responsibilities, time at home and what matters most to you. Delaying or reducing a medicine can be necessary for safety and does not itself prove treatment has failed.

Sources: nccp

TREATMENT REFERENCE · 02

Your treatment schedule

Use your prescription and team-confirmed calendar.

Medicines and sequence

On Day 1, irinotecan 165 mg/m² is infused over 90 minutes, followed by oxaliplatin 85 mg/m² and folinic acid 200 mg/m² over two hours. Fluorouracil 3,200 mg/m² is then delivered continuously over 48 hours. This regimen has no fluorouracil bolus. The team confirms your prescribed doses and disconnection time.

Sources: nccp

How long treatment lasts

There is no fixed number of cycles for everyone. Treatment is reviewed against cancer control, side effects and your priorities. A change to maintenance or a break is an individual decision.

Sources: nccp

The disconnection appointment

The fluorouracil infusion lasts 48 hours from connection. Arrange the completion visit before leaving the unit. Pump removal does not remove an implanted port: the port remains until a separate procedure is arranged.

Sources: nccp · pump

TREATMENT REFERENCE · 03

Before, during and after treatment

Testing detects problems that may not cause symptoms.

Before the first dose

Blood count, kidney and liver tests and DPD testing are required before fluoropyrimidine treatment unless the DPD test has already been done. DPD helps the body clear fluorouracil; deficiency changes the treatment plan. A normal result does not exclude all severe toxicity.

Sources: nccp

Before each cycle

Blood count, kidney and liver results and symptoms are reviewed before each cycle. Neuropathy is assessed every cycle; report troublesome symptoms sooner. Missing results are not assumed normal.

Sources: nccp

Heart tests are conditional

Tell the team about heart disease and previous chest symptoms. An ECG is needed when cardiac function is compromised or clinical findings warrant it. There is no automatic recurring echocardiogram schedule for every patient.

Sources: nccp

Scans, markers and aftercare

Your consultant decides response scans, tumour-marker use and follow-up according to your cancer and treatment aim. This regimen does not set one scan or marker interval for everyone. Unresolved side effects or abnormal blood results need a follow-up plan.

Sources: nccp

TREATMENT REFERENCE · 04

Bowel symptoms and hydration

Act early; do not wait for the next appointment.

Keep the written plan

Record the change from your usual bowel pattern, including stoma output. Keep the prescribed diarrhoea medicine and your oncology contact details available. Ask for specific instructions before the first treatment.

Sources: nccp

Two different irinotecan reactions

During or soon after infusion, cramps, sweating, a runny nose or diarrhoea can be an early cholinergic reaction: tell the nurse immediately. Diarrhoea starting more than 24 hours later needs the separate prescribed delayed-diarrhoea plan, which may differ from packet instructions. If it persists despite that plan, or you become unwell, seek urgent advice.

Sources: nccp

Urgent symptoms

Contact oncology urgently for persistent diarrhoea, inability to drink, reduced urine, dizziness, blood in stools, fever or severe abdominal pain. Do not assume severe abdominal pain is an ordinary treatment effect. A stoma can make fluid loss less obvious: report a marked increase in output.

Sources: nccp

TREATMENT REFERENCE · 05

Cold sensitivity and longer-lasting nerve symptoms

These are two related but different oxaliplatin problems.

Cold-triggered symptoms

Cold drinks, cold air and cold objects can bring on tingling or throat sensations. Avoid triggers and do not use ice chips during oxaliplatin treatment. New breathing difficulty still needs urgent assessment; it must not be diagnosed at home as simply a cold reaction.

Sources: nccp

Persistent neuropathy

Report numbness, tingling, pain or difficulty doing buttons, writing, holding objects or walking. Symptoms can accumulate over cycles and sometimes persist after treatment. Explain how long symptoms lasted and what activities changed.

Sources: nccp

Review before more oxaliplatin

Nerve assessment is required each cycle for this regimen. The team may change or stop oxaliplatin independently of the other medicines to reduce the risk of lasting harm. Do not wait for a scheduled assessment if symptoms are worsening.

Sources: nccp

TREATMENT REFERENCE · 06

Mouth, skin, energy and infection

Frequency and urgency are different.

Mouth and hands or feet

Fluorouracil can cause mouth ulcers and painful redness or peeling of hands and feet. Report symptoms early, especially if eating, drinking, walking or using your hands becomes difficult. Ask for non-irritating mouth care and skin-care advice.

Sources: nccp

Nausea, appetite and fatigue

Use the anti-sickness prescription and call if it is not controlling symptoms. Small regular meals and manageable activity with rest may help daily routines. Fatigue can have several causes; persistent or worsening fatigue may need blood tests or review. Irinotecan may also cause hair thinning or loss; ask about practical support.

Sources: nccp

Low blood counts and infection

Chemotherapy can reduce white cells, red cells and platelets. Fever, shivers or sudden illness needs immediate oncology advice, even if your temperature is not raised. Follow the unit's temperature instructions and do not wait for a scheduled blood test. Unusual bruising, bleeding, breathlessness or marked weakness also needs review.

Sources: nccp

Heart and infusion symptoms

Fluorouracil can rarely cause serious heart problems. Chest pain, collapse or severe breathing difficulty needs emergency assessment. Tell the nurse immediately if flushing, swelling, wheeze, rash or pain occurs during an infusion.

Sources: nccp

TREATMENT REFERENCE · 07

Your line and home pump

Ask for a demonstration and show the team what you would do.

Access and ordinary care

The team selects a port, PICC or other suitable access with you. Keep dressings and connections secure and follow the specific washing, bathing and activity instructions. Keep the pump away from excessive heat or cold.

Sources: port · picc · pump

Leak, disconnection or unexpected flow

Call the oncology contact for a leaking or disconnected pump, pain/swelling at the line, a pump that finishes early, or one that appears not to be delivering. Do not change settings or reconnect or disconnect the device unless specifically trained and instructed. Follow the spill/emergency steps the unit has taught you.

Sources: pump

Disconnection and future care

The pump is disconnected at the arranged visit and the line is cared for. A port needle can be removed while the implanted port stays under the skin. Ask when any dressing changes, flushes or later line removal are due.

Sources: port · picc · pump

TREATMENT REFERENCE · 08

Supportive medicines and daily life

The prescription changes with the active treatment.

Your supportive prescription

Confirm prevention and rescue medicines for nausea, the diarrhoea plan and any growth-factor injections. Atropine may be used before irinotecan for the early reaction; mention glaucoma and asthma. Do not duplicate anti-sickness medicines, start supplements or take leftover prescriptions without checking with the oncology pharmacist.

Sources: nccp

Medicines and interactions

Bring all prescribed and non-prescribed medicines, supplements and anticoagulants to review. Tell the team before starting antibiotics or a new medicine. Do not independently stop regular treatment such as anticoagulants before a procedure.

Sources: nccp

Fertility, pregnancy and sex

Discuss fertility preservation before starting where relevant. Ask which contraception, pregnancy, breastfeeding and sex precautions apply during treatment and after the last dose. The period depends on your medicines and circumstances.

Sources: nccp

Practical support

Ask about work, driving, travel, nutrition, caring responsibilities and emotional support. Report symptoms in terms of what you can eat, drink or do. An interpreter, another explanation or a written plan can help you and a chosen family member or carer.

Sources: nccp

Your paper plan, wallet card and contacts

The three-page summary and handbook are usable without a phone.

Carry the treatment card

The example telephone numbers on the wallet card are placeholders. Your team must replace them with working daytime and out-of-hours numbers before patient use. Keep the card with you; the QR opens the regimen information, not your confidential medical record.

Sources: nccp

Cycle and phase record

Ask the team to stamp or write the treatment actually given. For an open-ended course, use the passport for additional cycle records; blank spaces are not a prescribed number of treatments.

Sources: nccp

Before leaving

Confirm your next tests and appointments, pump disconnection when relevant, medicines to take at home and how to obtain urgent help. Explain the plan back in your own words; ask for anything unclear to be written down.

Sources: nccp

Understanding the evidence

Ask which study population and treatment sequence match your plan.

In a randomised study of people starting treatment for metastatic colorectal cancer, FOLFOXIRI improved tumour response and time before progression compared with FOLFIRI, and the study found a survival benefit. The more intensive combination also caused more severe side effects,

including low white-cell counts, diarrhoea and nerve symptoms. These group results do not predict an individual outcome.

Sources: trial

PREPARE FOR THE CONVERSATION

Questions worth asking

Does having more side effects mean treatment is working?

No. Side effects do not reliably show whether the cancer is responding. Report them so they can be treated. Your team assesses benefit using the tests and review plan appropriate to your cancer.

Why might a dose be delayed or reduced?

Your team may allow recovery, investigate a symptom or reduce the chance of lasting harm. Ask which drug changes, why, and when review is planned. A delay does not itself mean treatment has failed.

What should I say when calling?

Give the regimen name, last treatment date, symptoms and when they started. Explain whether you can eat, drink, pass urine and manage usual activities. Give your temperature if available, but do not delay calling to collect details.

What belongs in the consent conversation?

The individual aim and likely benefit, uncertainty, reasonable alternatives including not proceeding, common and serious risks, lasting effects, fertility and practical concerns. You can ask for an interpreter, more time or another explanation and can reconsider your decision.

How many cycles should I use this passport for?

The passport provides reusable recording pages, not a prescribed course length. Your oncology team sets the duration and can provide extra pages.

Will I need a port or a PICC?

The team chooses the most suitable access device with you. A port is under the skin; a PICC enters through the upper arm and has an external section. Both require specific care, and the pump can be used with either.

Does disconnecting the pump remove my port?

No. At the arranged visit the pump is disconnected and the line cared for. A port needle may be removed, but the implanted port stays under the skin until a separate removal procedure is arranged.

What if the pump finishes early or still looks full?

Contact the team for advice. Do not change delivery settings or disconnect or reconnect it yourself. Follow only the specific emergency steps you have been taught.

Is delayed diarrhoea the same as cramps during infusion?

No. Irinotecan can cause an early reaction with cramps, sweating or diarrhoea, and a later diarrhoea problem. Tell the nurse about early symptoms and follow the separate written plan at home.

Does the wallet QR contain my treatment record?

No. The printed QR opens this regimen’s patient information. Your cycle stamps, appointments, test results and treatment changes remain in your own records and the clinical record.

Can I use the printed information without a phone?

Yes. The three-page summary, full handbook and passport can be printed. Ask your team to write the next appointments and working contact numbers on the paper copies.

> **Try explaining the plan back:** Can you explain which medicines you are receiving, the schedule, the contact plan and the symptoms that need prompt help?

SOURCE TRANSPARENCY

Where this information comes from

Regimen schedule: NCCP 00555 v7. Medicine explanations and safety information: sources below. The timeline is an educational illustration, not a measured risk curve or an individual prediction.

- NCCP 00555 v7 · official regimen
- HSE: chemotherapy side effects and urgent advice
- eviQ: implanted port
- eviQ: PICC
- eviQ: infusion pump care
- GONO FOLFOXIRI versus FOLFIRI: Falcone et al. 2007

SACTCheck · Developed by Dr Paul O'Brien · Sources checked 2026-11-04.
This information supports your treatment discussion. Your oncology team confirms your personal treatment and urgent-care plan.

Written source addresses

https://healthservice.hse.ie/documents/6386/555_FOLFOXIRI_therapy.pdf

https://www.eviq.org.au/p/507

https://www.eviq.org.au/p/543

https://www.eviq.org.au/p/502

https://www2.hse.ie/conditions/chemotherapy/side-effects/

https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/17470860/